

Much the same goes for providing food and drink at game sessions — unless everyone is bringing their own to each session, make sure the burden doesn't fall too heavily on any one player. Whether everyone kicks in for a communal dinner, brings potluck to each session, or handles food on a rotating basis isn't as important as making sure it's fair, any dietary needs or allergies are accounted for, and nobody feels constantly put upon to provide for the rest of the group. Lighter, healthier fare like fruits and nuts, paired with juice or tea, can go a long way to keeping energy levels up and minds alert during a chapter.

Scheduling can be a source of real contention in a group, and so it's a good idea to have a frank discussion right up front about how often people expect to play, whether a session can be held with one or more members missing, if characters can be played in absentia by the Storyteller, whether alternates are permitted if a regular player misses a session, and so on. Trying to find a night where four or five people all have a few hours free to play and a way to get to the game can be a very difficult task, after all, let alone trying to do it 2-3 times per month.

For their part, players who have serious restrictions on their time should be reasonable about the rest of the group playing in their absence. By the same token, the Storyteller should make sure that such absent characters don't lag so far behind in terms of experience points or relevance to the story that the player feels there's no point in returning.

## The Golden Rule

Storytellers, if there is one great piece of advice to heed above all others, it's this:

*If following the rules and telling a great story ever conflict, always go with the story.*

Now, it's important to have rules, because without them it's hard to resolve conflicts and other uncertain situations fairly and predictably. Changing rules or setting elements constantly can make the players feel frustrated, to say the least, as they rely on those elements to understand the story and how they interact with it. That said, it is important to recognize that this book is here to serve as a guide, not a warden — it should inspire, not confine the imagination.

If it helps, think of rules in a roleplaying book as the sheet music in front of a jazz band. It's important to have it there so that everyone knows what's being played, when and how to play, and to keep everyone on the same page as the piece goes forward. Sometimes, however, the band is really feeling it and what's written down just isn't right, and that's when it's time to go off the page and improvise, to riff a bit and jam with each

other. Those are the same sorts of moments when going with the story over the rules is the right thing to do.

Only two essential guidelines need to be observed when changing rules or setting elements in this fashion. The first is that such changes must always be fair and consistent. Changing the rules to suit the needs of the group is fine, for instance, but not just for one player at the expense of the others, or at one time but not in another identical instance. The second is that any such changes should be announced clearly, so everyone knows what's being changed (and why), and preferably in advance if possible so that players have time to ask questions or discuss them. A Storyteller that follows those guidelines should be able to balance the need to have rules to provide a foundation for the game with the occasional necessity of bending or changing said rules to tell the best possible story.

After all, a lot of great roleplaying stories have been told that involved throwing out the rules at one point or another, but very few people fondly recall times when a good story ground to a halt in order to ensure the rules were being properly observed.

*Example: During a climactic confrontation with a dreaded chimerical monster that has been devouring neighborhood children, Mike wants his character, Mr. Sweets — a redcap ice cream truck driver — to Unleash the Winter Art to create a blizzard of ice cream treats at the voracious creature. He explains that he hopes the creature will gorge on the confections to the point where it gets sick and vomits back up the children it previously consumed.*

The rest of the table cheers at the idea and looks at Pete, the Storyteller, for a ruling. He knows that Unleashing a storm of ice cream isn't exactly in the usual redcap description, and those children were supposed to be long-since devoured beyond all hope of recovery. At the same time, Mike has a point that cold and hunger are thematic to redcaps, and both the ice cream and the rescue of children in danger suits the character of Mr. Sweets perfectly. It's not really what Unleashing is normally about, but it feels right in this case.

Pete thinks it over before granting the unusual request, though he asks Mike if he feels it's fair to also increase the difficulty of the related roll a bit due to the unusually specific nature of the Unleashing. Mike agrees that seems fair, and so the other players watch at the edge of their seats as he gets ready to make a difficult, high-stakes roll with the fate of their group and the endangered kids in the balance. What might have been a simple "no" according to the letter of the rules has become a very engaging moment due to heeding the spirit of the story instead.